A SERMON FOR THE PULPIT

The Man Who Pulled Down the House

A sermon on Samson

THE BIG IDEA

Samson pulled down Dagon's house with his own hands and died in the rubble; Jesus let his own house be pulled down and rose from it.

PRIMARY TEXT	Judges 16:4–31
ALSO READ	Judges 13–15; Hebrews 11:32; John 2:18–22; 2 Corinthians 12:9–10
TIME	50–60 minutes, including a 3–5 minute response.

Scripture quotations are ESV. Swap to your pulpit translation freely.

FIRST EDITION · OCTOBER 2026

Introduction: The strongest man in the room

Every children's Bible has a picture of Samson. He is usually smiling, with enormous arms and a lot of hair, standing beside a pile of rubble. The story we tell children is a superhero story: strong man, bad haircut, temple goes boom.

The actual story is a tragedy. It has more in common with a true-crime documentary than a comic book. There is a paid betrayal, a bag of silver, a man tortured and blinded, a crowded temple, and a final act of violence that kills thousands of people, including the man who did it. The book of Judges does not sanitize any of it.

And that is exactly why we need it. We live in a moment that worships strength. We follow the people with the biggest platforms, the loudest voices, the most impressive results. We measure pastors by attendance and leaders by output and people by what they can carry. The church is not immune. We have our own pantheon of strong men and women, and we often discover too late what it cost them, and us, to keep the image up. Samson is the patron saint of that temptation.

The story is also a mirror for anyone who has ever been given a gift they did not ask for and did not know how to carry. Samson never asked to be a Nazirite. He was set apart before he was born. He had a calling before he had a character. That is true of many of us. We were handed a ministry, a talent, a family name, a platform. And we have spent our lives trying to be strong enough to deserve it.

And yet this is one of the most important stories in the Bible for anyone who has ever been strong, or wanted to be, or been told that strength is the whole point.

Samson's story takes four chapters, longer than any other judge. We are given his birth, his calling, his gift, his appetites, his victories, his prayer, his death, and his burial. It is a whole life, told without flattery. And the last verse is not a victory parade. It is a grave.

Here is the big idea: Samson pulled down Dagon's house with his own hands and died in the rubble; Jesus let his own house be pulled down and rose from it.

That is where we are going. We are going to watch a man with everything except the one thing he thought he could manage. We are going to watch him lose it in the dark. And we are going to see a greater temple rise.

Let us read the story.

Movement 1: The gift and the secret

Start before the strength. Start with a barren woman and an angel.

Judges 13 opens with Israel again doing evil, and the LORD giving them into the hand of the Philistines for forty years. Then the angel of the LORD appears to Manoah's wife, who has no children, and says she will conceive and bear a son. The boy is to be a Nazirite from the womb. No wine or strong drink. No razor. No contact with the dead. "He shall begin to save Israel from the hand of the Philistines" (Judges 13:5).

Notice the word "begin." Samson begins a deliverance he never finishes. That is true of every human hero. We start things we cannot complete. We win battles that do not end the war. Samson is a beginning, not a fulfillment.

The Nazirite vow is described in Numbers 6. It is a vow of separation to the LORD. The uncut hair is not a magical battery. It is a visible sign that this person belongs to God in a particular way. The strength comes from the Spirit of the LORD, and the text says so again and again. The Spirit rushes upon Samson at Mahaneh Dan (13:25), against the lion (14:6), at Lehi (15:14). The hair is the sign. The Spirit is the source.

That distinction is the whole first movement.

Samson grows up and the Spirit begins to stir him. He sees a Philistine woman in Timnah and tells his parents, "Get her for me, for she is right in my eyes" (14:3). That phrase should sound familiar. It is the same phrase the book uses for Israel at the end: "Everyone did what was right in his own eyes" (21:25). Samson is Israel in one body. Gifted, called, set apart, and ruled by his own eyes.

He kills a lion with his bare hands. He turns the carcass into a riddle. He loses the riddle to a Philistine bride and her countrymen, and he pays the debt with the lives of thirty men from Ashkelon. He burns the Philistines' fields with foxes and torches. They burn his wife and her father. He strikes them "hip and thigh with a great blow" (15:8). They come for him, and he kills a thousand men with the jawbone of a donkey. Then he names the spring that saves his life.

It is one long streak of spectacular violence. And through it all, the Spirit keeps coming on him. God keeps using him. That is one of the most unsettling things about this story: God's gifts are not a diploma of good character. A man can be used by God and still be lost in his own appetites.

Then comes Gaza. Samson goes in to a prostitute, and the men of Gaza plan an ambush. He stays until midnight, then gets up, takes hold of the doors of the city gate and the two posts, and carries them on his shoulders to the top of the hill near Hebron (16:1–3). It is a display of raw power and a picture of his recklessness. He takes the security of a city and leaves it on a hill, but he does not take the city. He wins a spectacle, not a victory. He is strong enough to humiliate his enemies and not wise enough to free his people.

"After this he loved a woman in the Valley of Sorek, whose name was Delilah" (16:4).

The text says he loved her. Not merely desired her. That makes the betrayal worse. The Valley of Sorek is Philistine country, a corridor between the hill country and the coast. He is in enemy territory again, and this time he thinks he is there for love.

The lords of the Philistines come to Delilah with a business proposition. "Seduce him, and see where his great strength lies, and by what means we may overpower him, that we may bind him to humble him. And we will each give you 1,100 pieces of silver" (16:5). Five lords. Five thousand five hundred pieces of silver. This is not a petty bribe. It is a state contract. They do not want Samson dead. They want to know the secret of his strength. They want to own the source.

Delilah asks him. He lies. Seven fresh bowstrings. New ropes. The loom. Each time she cries, "The Philistines are upon you, Samson!" and each time he snaps the trap and walks away. The men in ambush wait in the inner chamber. The whole thing is a game, and Samson thinks he is the one winning it.

Why does he stay? Because he believes he is in control. That is the delusion of every person playing with fire. I know where the line is. I can handle it. I will stop before it matters. The strongest man in the world was not strong enough to leave the room.

Then Delilah asks the question that breaks him open: "How can you say, 'I love you,' when your heart is not with me? You have mocked me these three times, and you have not told me where your great strength lies" (16:15). She has been lying to him from the start, and she accuses him of not giving her his heart. It is a terrible mirror. But she is also right about the structure of the relationship. He has been giving her answers, not himself.

"And when she pressed him hard with her words day after day, and urged him, his soul was vexed to death. And he told her all his heart" (16:16–17).

That phrase, "all his heart," is the tragedy. He had kept the secret of his strength from everyone. Now he gives it to the one person who is being paid to take it.

"A razor has never come upon my head, for I have been a Nazirite to God from my mother's womb. If my head is shaved, then my strength will leave me, and I shall become weak and be like any other man" (16:17).

Listen to what he says. "My strength." Not "the LORD's strength." The gift has become his possession. He is not guarding a vow anymore. He is guarding an asset. He has already lost the plot. The secret was never a what. It was a Who. The hair was the sign. The Spirit was the source.

And that is the first thing this story asks us: what are you treating as the source that is only the sign?

Movement 2: The night he did not know

Delilah sees that he has told her everything. She calls the lords. They come with the silver. She puts Samson to sleep on her knees, and a man shaves the seven locks of his head. "And his strength left him" (16:19).

The text does not say the hair was magic. It says his strength left him. The sign of his consecration was gone. The vow was broken. And the LORD, who had been the source of every victory, was no longer with him in the same way.

Then comes the sentence I want us to sit in.

"She said, 'The Philistines are upon you, Samson!' And he awoke from his sleep and said, 'I will go out as at other times and shake myself free.' But he did not know that the LORD had left him" (16:20).

"As at other times."

That is how it works. The same alarm. The same muscles. The same escape plan. The same assumption that God will be there because God was there the last time. He had no idea that the last "other time" had already happened.

"But he did not know that the LORD had left him."

This is one of the saddest sentences in the Bible. It does not say he did not know his hair was gone. He could feel the air on his scalp. It says he did not know the LORD had left. He had lost the source and was still running on the memory of the current. He reached for the old strength and found only his own arm.

That is the spiritual nightmare: the old motions with no presence. A ministry still operating. A reputation still intact. A body still moving. A schedule still full. And the glory gone.

I have seen it in a man who preached the same sermons for twenty years and could not tell you the last time he prayed alone. I have seen it in a woman who led the worship team and went home to a silence she could not explain. I have seen it in myself. The terrifying thing about Samson's night is not that he was attacked. It is that he was attacked and did not notice the difference. He had been shaved while he slept. Most of us are not shaved in our sleep. We are shaved slowly, by a thousand small compromises, and we call it normal.

I need to be careful here. The text is not teaching that a believer can lose salvation. It is telling us that the Spirit's empowerment for Samson's calling was withdrawn. But the warning is real, and it is for every one of us: you can have the gifts of God operating in your life and not have the fellowship of God in your walk. You can be busy in the house and a stranger to the Lord of the house. "Many will say to me on that day, 'Lord, Lord, did we not prophesy in your name?' … And then will I declare to them, 'I never knew you'" (Matthew 7:22–23). The point is not to make you doubt your salvation. The point is to stop you from assuming that activity equals intimacy.

The Philistines seize him. They gouge out his eyes. They bind him with bronze shackles and bring him down to Gaza. And he grinds grain in the prison (16:21).

The man who carried the gates of Gaza now walks in circles with a millstone. The eyes that looked on the lion, the woman, the escape route, are gone. The strong man is led by a boy. The judge of Israel is a grinding slave. The text is unflinching. Sin pays its wages in the body.

Think about the irony. The man who was born to begin the deliverance of Israel is now doing the work of a donkey in a Philistine prison. The man who carried the gates of a city cannot carry himself. The man who could not be bound with seven bowstrings or new ropes is now bound with bronze. Sin does not just take your strength. It takes your freedom, your sight, your dignity, and your name. It makes you a servant of the thing you thought you were mastering.

Long before they took his eyes, he had stopped seeing. He could see the woman. He could see the silver. He could see the way out. He could not see himself. The first blindness was not in Gaza. It was in his heart.

And that is the blindness we all share. We can see everyone else's faults with perfect clarity. We can see the speck in our brother's eye from across the room. We cannot see the log in our own. We can see the way our spouse needs to change, the way our boss is wrong, the way our

church is failing. We cannot see the pattern in ourselves that everyone who loves us has been trying to name for years. Samson was not the only person in this story who could not see.

Then one small verse: "But the hair of his head began to grow again after it had been shaved" (16:22).

It is the first sign of hope in the story. But it is not magic. The hair growing is not the strength returning. The next time he needs strength, he asks for it. The hair is the sign of the vow. The sign is coming back. The question is whether the LORD will return.

The text leaves that question hanging until the temple.

Movement 3: The prayer in the dark

"Now the lords of the Philistines gathered to offer a great sacrifice to Dagon their god and to rejoice, and they said, 'Our god has given Samson our enemy into our hand.' And when the people saw him, they praised their god, for they said, 'Our god has given our enemy into our hand, the ravager of our country, who has killed many of us'" (16:23–24).

They credit Dagon. The narrator lets them say it. But the reader knows better. Dagon did not do this. The LORD did, because Samson broke the vow and the LORD had left him. And yet the LORD is not done. The Philistines are wrong in both directions: they think their god has won, and they think Samson is finished. Both assumptions are about to be corrected.

The crowd is merry. They call for Samson to entertain them. The word is "play" or "make sport." The judge of Israel is a party favor. They stand him between the two pillars that hold up the roof. The house is full of men and women, all the lords of the Philistines, and about three thousand more on the roof, watching (16:27). The whole power structure of Philistia is in one building, laughing at a blind man.

This is what the world does with a broken hero. It puts him on display. It makes him a joke. It celebrates the ruin of the person it once feared. The Philistines are not content to have won; they need to see him humiliated. And that is the moment God chooses to answer a prayer. Not in the palace, not on the battlefield, not in the years of strength, but in the temple of the enemy, with a blind man's hands on the pillars. God specializes in the places we would never choose.

Samson asks the young man who holds his hand, "Let me touch the pillars on which the house rests, that I may lean against them" (16:26). He is not looking for a way out. He is looking for a way through.

Then he prays. "O Lord GOD, please remember me and please strengthen me only this once, O God, that I may be avenged on the Philistines for my two eyes" (16:28).

Look at the prayer closely. It is short. It is honest. It is mixed.

He uses the covenant name. "Lord GOD." He asks to be remembered. He asks for strength, not escape. He does not confess the sin with Delilah. He does not ask for forgiveness. He asks for revenge. "For my two eyes." This is not a model of Christian piety. It is a model of honesty. He brings his ruin and his rage to God. And God answers.

There is a kind of prayer that tries to clean itself up before it comes to God. It starts with explanation, moves through apology, and ends with a plan. It is impressive, and it is exhausting. Samson's prayer is none of that. It is the raw speech of a ruined man. And God hears it. If you have been waiting to pray until you have yourself together, you have misunderstood the God you are praying to. He is not impressed by your composure. He is near to the brokenhearted.

Why does God answer? Not because Samson earned it. Not because revenge is righteous. Because God had a purpose for Samson's life, to begin to save Israel from the Philistines. And because God is the kind of God who remembers. "Remember" is covenant language. God remembered Noah. God remembered Abraham. God remembered Rachel. God remembered Israel in Egypt. To ask God to remember is to ask him to be faithful to his own character and his own promise. Samson has nothing to appeal to except God's memory. That is the only plea any of us has.

Notice also what Samson does not do. He does not say, "I have learned my lesson." He does not promise to be a better Nazirite. He does not offer to lead Israel again. He does not even ask to see. He asks to be remembered. That is the prayer of a man who has run out of everything except God. And it is the most honest prayer in the book of Judges.

He takes the two middle pillars, one with his right hand and one with his left. He leans his weight against them. "And Samson said, 'Let me die with the Philistines.' Then he bowed with all his might, and the house fell upon the lords and upon all the people who were in it. So the dead whom he killed at his death were more than those whom he had killed during his life" (16:30).

The narrator gives us the number and lets it sit there. It is not a triumph. It is a body count. The strongest man in the world saved his people by dying in the wreckage of a pagan temple, and the last thing he saw was nothing.

Do not glorify this. Do not turn it into a poster. This is not a template for violence, and it is not a model for suicide. The text reports it; it does not baptize it. A man gifted by God, called from the womb, ends his life in a blind act of vengeance. That is tragedy. And grace is real too: God heard him. Both are true. Hold them together.

If you are in that place tonight, if the thought of ending your life has become a companion, please hear me: this story is not telling you to do that. Samson's death is a tragedy, not a command. Talk to someone. Call a pastor, a friend, a crisis line. Your life is not a debt to be settled by violence against yourself. The One who made you is not done with you.

The prayer in the dark is the turning point of the story. Not because Samson finally becomes a good man. Because he finally stops pretending he is strong. He has no hair, no eyes, no freedom, no reputation, and no plan. He has a prayer. And a prayer is enough.

But notice the shape of the answer. God does not remove the consequences. Samson does not get his eyes back. He does not get out of the temple. He does not get to grow old in his father's house. The answer comes through the wreckage, not around it. That is important, because we often want God to undo the damage rather than to be with us in it. The gospel does not promise that our sin will have no consequences. It promises that our sin will not have the last word.

Movement 4: The burial and the record

"Then his brothers and all his father's family came down and took him and brought him up and buried him between Zorah and Eshtaol in the tomb of Manoah his father. And he had judged Israel twenty years" (16:31).

The men who come for the body. It is a quiet ending. The family that had been embarrassed by him, the tribe that had handed him over to the Philistines (15:9–13), comes to bury him. They bring him home. The hero comes home in a coffin.

There is something deeply human about that. The people who knew him first, who changed his diapers and watched him grow, are the ones who come to carry him home. The family that could not control him can at least bury him. It is the last dignity of a tragic life: someone

remembers where you belong. And it is a small echo of a greater burial, where another body was taken down from a cross and laid in a borrowed tomb.

Between Zorah and Eshtaol is where the Spirit first began to stir him (13:25). The story ends where it began. The tomb of Manoah his father. A family grave.

And the record: "He had judged Israel twenty years." That is the summary. Not "he was a good man." Not "he was a failure." The narrator gives him the title. He did judge Israel for twenty years. The gift was real. The calling was real. The deliverance was real, even if it was partial. His life was not nothing. His death was not nothing. God used him.

That is a hard sentence for us. We want the story to be simpler. We want the hero to be good or the villain to be evil. But grace is not a simple story. God used a man who broke his vow, slept with the enemy, and died in an act of revenge. If that troubles you, it should. It troubled the biblical writers too. The book of Judges is not a celebration of Samson. It is a portrait of what happens when God's people are left to their own devices, and God gifts them anyway.

That is not a reason to stay flawed. It is a reason to be amazed at grace.

But the record is also a warning. The book of Judges ends with "everyone did what was right in their own eyes" (21:25). Samson is the poster child. The people wanted a king. They wanted someone to fight for them. God gave them judges, but the judges were mirrors of the people. Samson was Israel in one body: set apart, gifted, called, and unable to keep the vow. The book ends in civil war and chaos. The problem was not the absence of a strong man. It was the absence of a faithful God in the hearts of his people.

Then there is Hebrews 11. Samson is in the hall of faith. That surprises people. "And what more shall I say? For time would fail me to tell of Gideon, Barak, Samson, Jephthah, of David and Samuel and the prophets" (Hebrews 11:32). Why is Samson there? Not because his life was exemplary. Because faith, even the size of a mustard seed, is what lays hold of God. His final prayer is faith mixed with vengeance, and it is still faith. He asked God to remember him, and God did. The hall of faith is not a hall of fame for perfect people. It is a hall of grace for people who cried out.

Think about what that means for the person in this room who thinks their story is already over. If Samson can be named among the faithful, your past is not a lock on your future. But think about what it means for the person who is still playing games with sin. If Samson's name is in the hall of faith, it is because he cried out at the end, not because he was safe in the middle. Do not presume on the end while you are still running toward the dark.

Do not use grace as a license. The same chapter that names Samson names the cost of faith. The gospel is not "God uses bad people, so stay bad." It is "God saves bad people, so come as you are and let him change you."

The burial also points forward. A family tomb. A dead judge. A people still waiting. There is another story coming. There is a king coming. There is a temple coming.

The rest of the Old Testament is the story of that waiting. Israel gets a king, and the king builds a temple, and the temple is destroyed, and the people come back and build another one. And still the story is not finished. The prophets keep saying that God will come to his temple. And then one day, a man walks into it and says, "Destroy this temple."

Movement 5: The temple that rose

Samson pulled down the temple of Dagon. But there was another temple, and another house, and another death.

The Jews came to Jesus in the temple courts and asked for a sign. "Jesus answered them, 'Destroy this temple, and in three days I will raise it up.' The Jews then said, 'It has taken forty-six years to build this temple, and will you raise it up in three days?' But he was speaking about the temple of his body. When therefore he was raised from the dead, his disciples remembered that he had said this, and they believed the Scripture and the word that Jesus had spoken" (John 2:19–22).

Hold the two scenes side by side in your mind. In Gaza, the temple is full of people who have gathered to praise a god who did not save them. In Jerusalem, the temple is full of people who have gathered to buy and sell and to demand a sign. In Gaza, the house falls. In Jerusalem, the temple of God is torn down in the body of Jesus. Both look like the end of hope. Only one is.

Samson stood between two pillars and pulled the house down. Jesus stood in the temple courts and said, "Destroy this temple." He was not the one pulling it down. He was the one letting it be pulled down. He did not take his own life. He gave it. "No one takes it from me, but I lay it down of my own accord. I have authority to lay it down, and I have authority to take it up again" (John 10:18). His death was not a suicide. It was a sacrifice.

Run the contrast slowly.

Samson's strength was in his body. Jesus' strength was in his obedience. Samson's hair was the sign. Jesus is the substance. Samson's eyes were gouged out. Jesus' eyes were closed in death

and opened in resurrection. Samson prayed, "Remember me," and was heard for a moment. Jesus is the one in whom God remembers us forever. Samson died to kill his enemies. Jesus died to save his. Samson's death killed more than his life. Jesus' death saved more than his life ever could.

Samson's story ends in a tomb between Zorah and Eshtaol. Jesus' tomb is empty.

And that is the difference between Samson's story and ours. Samson's death ended his judgeship. Jesus' death ended his death. Samson's body was buried by his family. Jesus' body was buried by a stranger and raised by the Father. The comparison is not a slight to Samson. It is a glimpse of how far the grace of God will go. We were all Samson. We had all lost the source and kept the sign. And God did not send another judge. He came himself.

Samson's last word was, "Let me die with the Philistines." Jesus' last words from the cross were, "Father, forgive them, for they know not what they do" (Luke 23:34), and, "It is finished" (John 19:30). The contrast is not between a bad man and a good man. It is between the first Adam and the last Adam. Samson is what we are. Jesus is what we need.

The apostle Paul learned this. He had his own strength, his own pedigree, his own résumé. And God gave him a thorn in the flesh to keep him from exalting himself. He pleaded three times for it to be removed. And God said, "My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness." Paul answered, "Therefore I will boast all the more gladly of my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest upon me" (2 Corinthians 12:9).

The gospel does not recruit heroes. It raises the dead. It takes blind men and gives them sight. It takes the strength we are so proud of and breaks it, and then it gives us a strength that is not ours. Samson's strength was in his hair and his muscles. Paul's strength was in his weakness. The Christian life is not "be strong for God." It is "be weak enough to let God be strong for you."

There is one more thing. The temple of Jesus' body is not the only temple in the New Testament. "Do you not know that your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit within you, whom you have from God?" (1 Corinthians 6:19). The Spirit who rushed on Samson is the Spirit who lives in us. But the Spirit is not a power we use. He is a person we obey. The sign of his presence is not only power. It is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, self-control (Galatians 5:22–23). Samson had power without character. The fruit of the Spirit is the character of Christ.

So the gospel comes to two people tonight.

It comes to the strong person who has been running on "as at other times." You have been the Samson of your family, your church, your team. You have been the one who handles things. You are tired. You do not have to pull the house down. Come out of the dark.

It comes to the broken person who thinks their failure is the end of the story. Look at the text. The last thing Samson did was pray, and God heard him. The Lord is not finished with you. Come out of the dark.

The strongest man in the world died blind. The Son of God went into the dark for him, and came out alive.

Application: What do you do with the strength?

Four responses.

1. Name the gift, not just the muscle

Samson's gift was the Spirit. His muscles were the result. Your gift may be your mind, your voice, your money, your leadership, your body, your compassion. Name it. Thank God for it. Steward it. But do not confuse the gift with the Giver. The gift is not the whole calling. Character is the container that holds the gift. If the container cracks, the gift leaks. Samson had a hole in his character the size of his appetite, and everything God gave him ran out through it.

Think about the person who is the strongest in the room. Everyone brings their problems to them. They are the fixer, the provider, the one who holds it together. And because they are strong, no one asks how they are. The gift becomes a cage. If that is you, hear this: you are allowed to need help. The strongest man in the Bible needed a boy to lead him by the hand. Strength that cannot admit need is not strength; it is fear wearing armor.

2. Do not confuse the sign with the source

The hair was the sign. The Spirit was the source. Our signs are good things: ministry success, theological knowledge, moral discipline, a platform, a reputation, a family, a church. But if you lose the source and keep the sign, you become a moving performance with no power. The sign is not the source. The routine is not the relationship. The reputation is not the presence. Ask yourself: where am I trusting the sign? What would I do if the sign were taken away? Would I still have God?

A pastor can preach a sermon that moves a room and go home to a prayer life that is a dry well. A mother can hold everyone together and never let anyone hold her. A leader can make every

decision and never ask God for one. The sign keeps working. The source has been quietly left behind.

3. Tell the truth about your eyes

Samson's physical blindness is a picture of his spiritual blindness. He saw the woman, the silver, and the way out. He did not see himself. The first step out of the dark is to admit you are in it. Who has been telling you the truth about yourself, and what have you done with them? Delilah asked the right question for the wrong reason: "Your heart is not with me." Let the people who love you ask that question. Secrecy is the seed of the fall. Bring it into the light.

Jesus said, "The eye is the lamp of the body. If your eye is healthy, your whole body will be full of light" (Matthew 6:22). Samson's problem was not a lack of information. It was a lack of vision. He could not see the end of his own appetite. Neither can we, without help. That is why community matters. That is why confession matters. That is why we need people in our lives who are close enough to say, "You are not seeing this."

4. Pray the small prayer

"Remember me." Not a long prayer. Not a bargain. Not a promise to do better. Just the cry of a blind man. The tax collector prayed, "God, be merciful to me, a sinner" (Luke 18:13). The thief on the cross prayed, "Jesus, remember me when you come into your kingdom" (Luke 23:42). That is the same prayer. And the answer is better than Samson's: "Today you will be with me in paradise" (Luke 23:43). The small prayer is enough. Come to the One who remembers.

The prayer is small, but it is not magic. It does not undo the past. It does not restore your eyes. It does not get you out of prison. What it does is put you in the hands of the God who remembers. And that is enough for the next step.

These four responses are not steps to becoming a hero. They are the way home for a person who has stopped pretending. Name the gift. Trust the source. Open your eyes. Pray the small prayer. And then get up and walk in the light you have.

The invitation

This invitation is for two people.

The first is the strong one. You have been the Samson of your family, your church, your team. You have been running on the memory of the last time God used you. You are tired. You do not have to pull the house down. Come out of the dark.

The second is the broken one. You think your failure is the end of your story. Look at the text. The last thing Samson did was pray, and God heard him. The Lord is not finished with you. Come out of the dark.

You do not have to be strong to come. You have to be honest. You do not have to have a plan. You have to have a prayer. You do not have to fix your life before you come. You have to bring it. And if all you can say is "Remember me," that is enough. The Lord has never turned away a person who came to him in the dark.

The gospel is for both. The strongest man in the world died blind. Jesus went into the dark for him. He will meet you there.

Response

In a moment, I am going to ask you to do something simple. Not to come forward. Not to stand. Not to sing. Just to be quiet.

In the quiet, name the sign. What are you trusting instead of the source? A role. A reputation. A routine. A gift. A relationship. A version of yourself you have been performing. Say it to God. Do not defend it. Do not explain it. Just name it.

Then name the eyes. Where have you stopped seeing? Where have you been blind to your own patterns, your own appetite, your own need? Ask God to show you. Ask someone who loves you to tell you the truth. And then listen to them. Do not argue. Do not explain. Let the light in.

Then name the secret. What is the thing you have been keeping in the dark? What is the "all his heart" you have been handing to the wrong person, or to no one at all? You do not have to announce it to the room. But you do have to stop pretending it is not there. Bring it to God. Bring it to one trusted person.

Then pray the small prayer. "Lord, remember me." Not ten sentences. One. Let it be small and true.

If you are in danger of harming yourself, please do not leave here alone. Speak to me, an elder, a trusted friend, or call your local emergency number or a crisis line right now. Samson's death is a tragedy, not a model. Your life is a gift, and God is not done with you.

Let us pray.

Lord Jesus, you are the true temple. You let your body be broken so that we could be put back together. You went into the dark so that we would never be alone there. Forgive us for trusting the sign instead of the source. Forgive us for using your gifts while ignoring your presence. Open our eyes to see ourselves, and then open our eyes to see you. Remember us, not because we are strong, but because you are faithful. Make us a church where the strong can be honest and the broken can be found. And when our strength is gone, be our strength. We ask this in your name. Amen.

Closing

They buried him between Zorah and Eshtaol, in the tomb of Manoah his father. And he had judged Israel twenty years.

That is where the story ends. A blind man in a family grave.

But there is another tomb.

The strongest man in the world died in the dark. The Son of God went into the dark for him, and came out alive. He is still opening eyes. He is still remembering. He is still calling people out of the dark.

And the voice you hear is not asking you to be stronger. It is asking you to come.

Come out of the dark.

Evidence note for the preacher

- Judges 13–16 is the longest judge cycle in the book. Samson is the only judge whose birth is announced by an angel, the only judge with a lifelong Nazirite calling, and the only judge whose death is reported in detail. The narrative is theological history, not a hero legend; the narrator shows Samson's flaws without excusing them.
- The Nazirite vow is defined in Numbers 6:1–21. It involved abstaining from wine and strong drink, not cutting the hair, and avoiding contact with a dead body. Samson's vow is from the womb (Judges 13:5, 7). He violates the corpse prohibition in Judges 14:8–9 (the lion's carcass and the honey) and is at least present at a drinking feast in 14:10; the text does not explicitly say he drank. The hair is the sign of the vow, not the source of his strength.
- The source of Samson's strength is the Spirit of the LORD: Judges 13:25; 14:6, 19; 15:14. The formula "the Spirit of the LORD rushed upon him" is charismatic empowerment for a task, not a guarantee of character. Judges 16:20 says the LORD had left him; this is the withdrawal of that empowering presence, not a proof text about the loss of salvation.

- "Samson" (Shimshon) may be connected to the Hebrew word for "sun" (shemesh), and Beth-shemesh means "house of the sun." The etymology is suggestive, not certain, and the sermon does not build on it.
- Delilah is named but not called a prostitute in the text; the woman in Gaza (16:1) is. Her name's etymology is uncertain. She is a free agent who makes a calculated deal with the Philistine lords. The sermon avoids making her the sole villain; Samson's own choices are the narrative's focus.
- The five lords of the Philistines represent the pentapolis: Gaza, Ashkelon, Ashdod, Ekron, and Gath (1 Samuel 6:17). The offer of 1,100 pieces of silver each, 5,500 total, is an enormous sum, signaling a state-level operation, not a private grudge.
- Judges 16:13–14 (the weaving of the locks into the loom) is longer in the Masoretic Text than in some Septuagint witnesses. The sermon follows the ESV. The three failed attempts are a literary pattern; they show Delilah's persistence and Samson's willingness to play with the secret.
- Gaza was a major Philistine city. Grinding grain at a mill was typically women's work and a symbol of humiliation and captivity (compare Lamentations 5:13; Isaiah 47:2). Bronze shackles and blinding were common ways to neutralize a captured ruler or enemy (compare 2 Kings 25:7; Jeremiah 39:7). The "young man" who leads Samson by the hand (16:26) is a final image of reversal.
- Dagon was a Philistine national deity, associated with grain and fertility. The temple in Gaza is not archaeologically identified. Philistine temples with two central pillars supporting a roof are attested at Tel Qasile, which makes the narrative's architecture plausible; the sermon does not claim to have found the Gaza temple. The crowd on the roof (16:27) fits the design of a large temple complex with a flat roof.
- The line "the dead whom he killed at his death were more than those whom he had killed during his life" (16:30) is the narrator's ironic summary, not a moral endorsement. The text reports Samson's suicide-adjacent prayer ("Let me die with the Philistines") without commanding or commending it. Preach it as tragedy and grace, not as a template for violence or self-harm. Provide pastoral care and crisis resources in the response.
- Hebrews 11:32 lists Samson among the faithful. This is grace, not approval of everything he did. The point is that faith, even a flawed and desperate faith, lays hold of God. The sermon does not claim Samson was a model of sanctification; it claims the God who remembers is faithful.
- The book of Judges ends with the refrain "everyone did what was right in their own eyes" (17:6; 21:25). Samson's phrase "she is right in my eyes" (14:3) uses the same language. The Samson cycle is a mirror of Israel's condition and a argument for the need for a faithful king.
- The gospel connection is a contrast, not a one-to-one allegory. John 2:19–22 identifies Jesus' body as the true temple; John 10:18 says he laid down his life willingly; 1 Corinthians 6:19 says the Spirit makes believers temples. The sermon uses Samson as a foil for Christ, not as a hidden prophecy of every detail.
- The final prayer of Samson ("please remember me") and the thief's prayer ("Jesus, remember me," Luke 23:42) share the same verb. The connection is intended and is one of the sermon's pastoral bridges. The thief receives the answer Samson's story points toward: "Today you will be with me in paradise" (Luke 23:43).

- Scripture quotations are ESV.